



NODUS · COMPLETE VAULT GUIDE

Genealogy

Reconstruct people, families and events without losing the documentary trail.

The Genealogy vault connects a family tree to people, life events, places, social relations, archival records and research notes. Every relationship can be reviewed against evidence.

VERSION	Nodus 4.1
UPDATED	14 August 2026
AUDIENCE	Family historians, genealogists and local-history researchers.

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Core operation, configuration and the complete vault workflow.

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PART I · FOUNDATION

Core Nodus workflow

Start here if Nodus is new to you. These chapters explain what a vault is, how to move through the application, how sources remain traceable, when a model is optional and how to keep a recoverable copy of the work.

START HERE

1 Welcome to Nodus

Nodus is a local-first desktop workspace for research, teaching and study. Work is organised into focused vaults that share one private engine.

A vault is an independent workspace for one project, course, family or dataset. Changing the vault changes the navigation and assistant context, while the database, indexes and preserved files stay on the computer. Accounts are optional, and model-assisted features run only after a provider or local model has been configured.

WHERE TO FIND IT

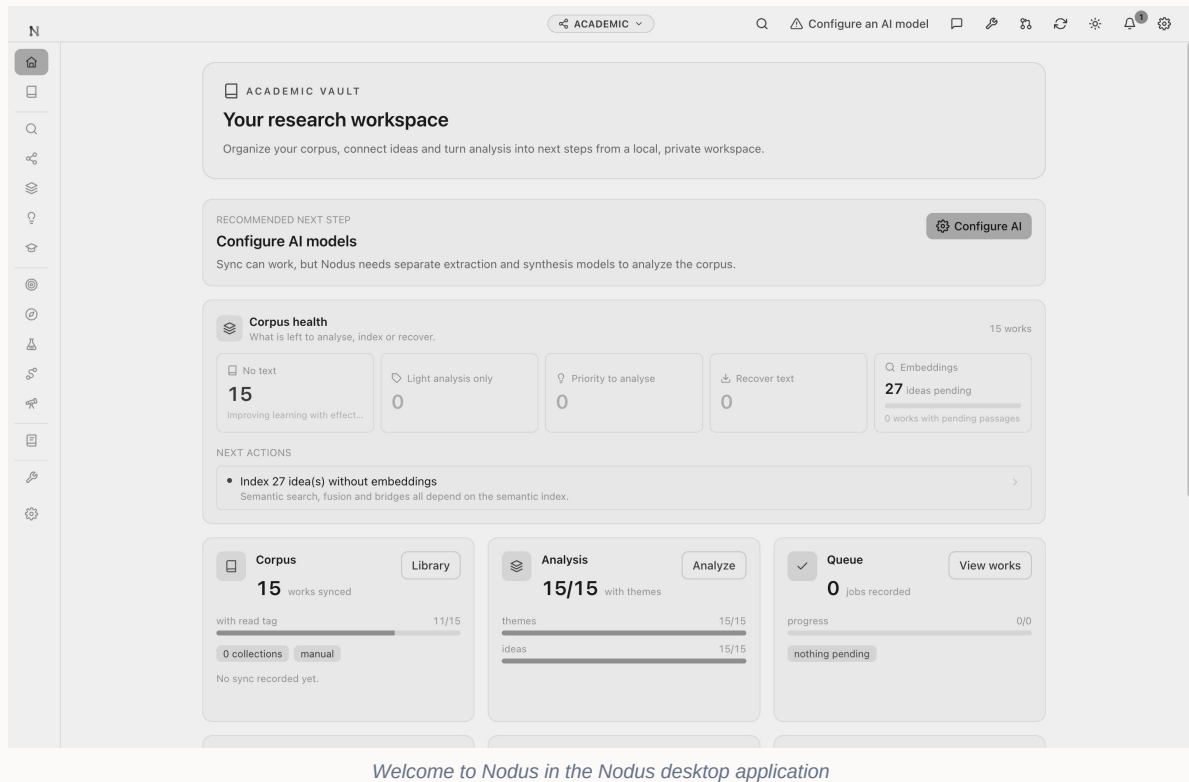
Install Nodus, then open the application

STEP BY STEP

1. Download the package for macOS, Windows or Linux from the Nodus release page and complete the installer.
2. Launch Nodus and complete the short setup: appearance, optional Nodi assistant and the introductory tour.
3. Create the vault that matches the work you are starting, give it a clear name and remain on Home while you learn the layout.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use one vault per coherent project, course, family or dataset.
- Start with a small set of real material that you are allowed to process.



START HERE

2 Create and switch vaults

Create independent workspaces and move between them without mixing their context.

The vault switcher is the boundary between projects. Each vault has its own notes, analysis and domain records, while the global Library can link the same source into compatible vaults without duplicating it.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Application header → vault name and icon

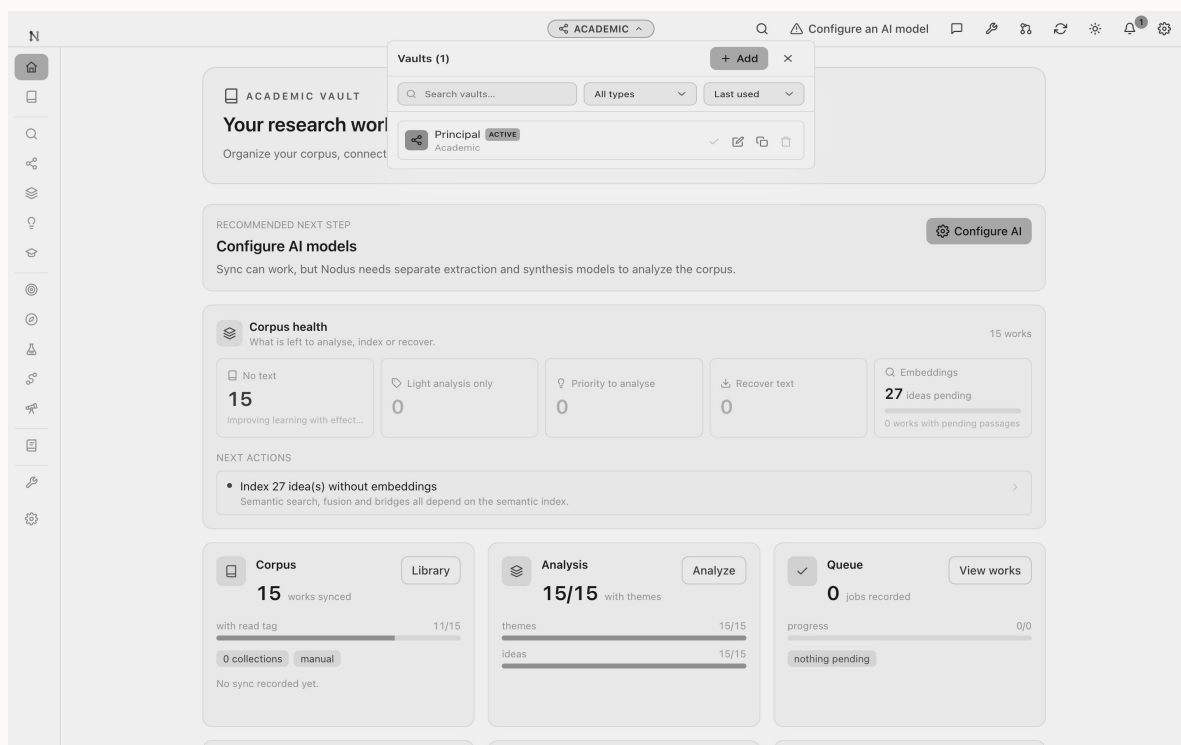
STEP BY STEP

1. Select the current vault name in the centre of the application header, then choose the action to create a vault.
2. Enter a descriptive name, select the correct vault type and read the explanation of the workflow it enables before confirming.
3. Open the same switcher whenever you need another project; choose a vault and wait for its Home view to appear.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use explicit names such as 'MA thesis - memory' or 'Biology 2026'.

- Create a new vault instead of changing the meaning of a mature workspace.



Create and switch vaults in the Nodus desktop application

ESSENTIALS

3 Navigation and global search

The sidebar exposes the workflow for the active vault; search retrieves material across the relevant local index.

The narrow left sidebar contains the active vault's tools. Hover an icon to read its label. The magnifying-glass button opens search, while the vault button in the header changes workspace. Keyword search works immediately; semantic retrieval also requires an embedding model.

WHERE TO FIND IT

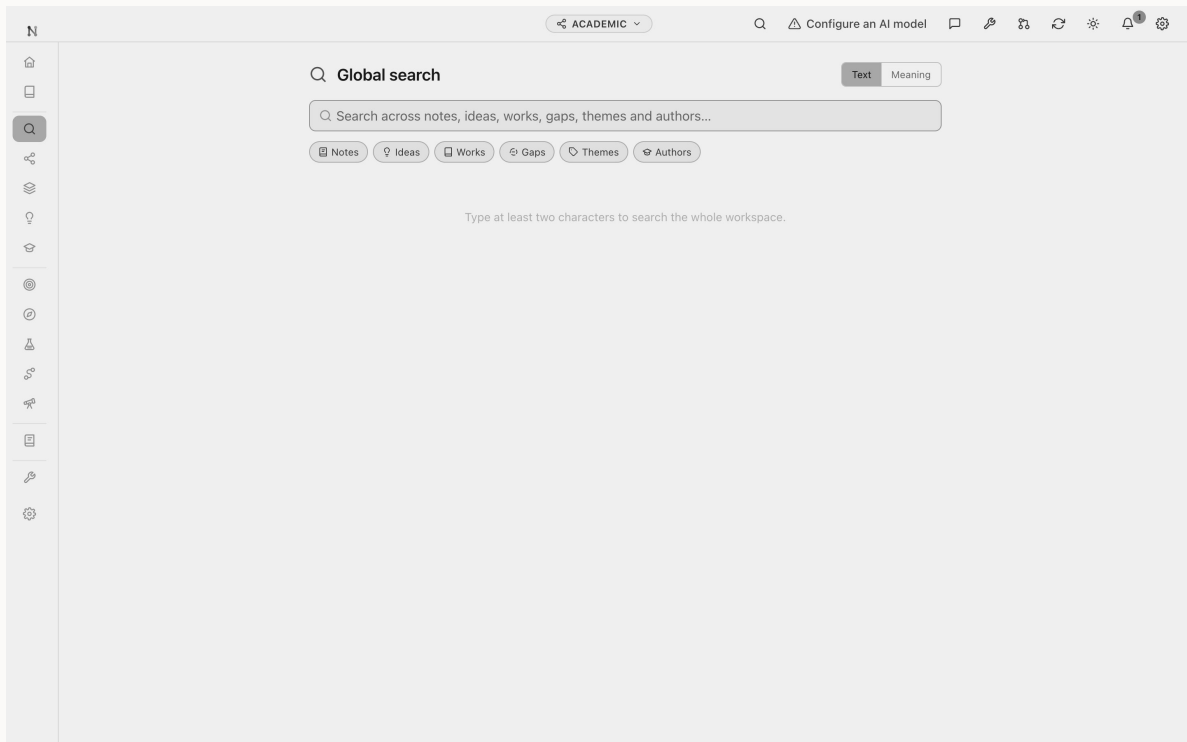
Left sidebar → magnifying-glass icon

STEP BY STEP

1. Move the pointer over sidebar icons until the label for the section you need appears, then select it; the active icon receives the vault colour.
2. Open Search and enter a title, name, quotation or concept of at least two meaningful characters.
3. Apply a type or scope filter when available, open a result and follow its source link to the original document, record, person or note.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Search for concepts as well as exact titles.
- Rebuild an index from Settings if recently imported content does not appear.



Navigation and global search in the Nodus desktop application

ESSENTIALS

4 Library, sources and reader

Keep preserved originals beside clean reading copies, citations, highlights and extracted evidence.

The cross-vault Library can mirror Zotero, import RIS, BibTeX and CSL JSON, or accept files directly. Nodus preserves the original attachment and creates searchable derivatives. Compatible sources can be linked to several vaults without copying the original.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Nodus → Library, sources and reader

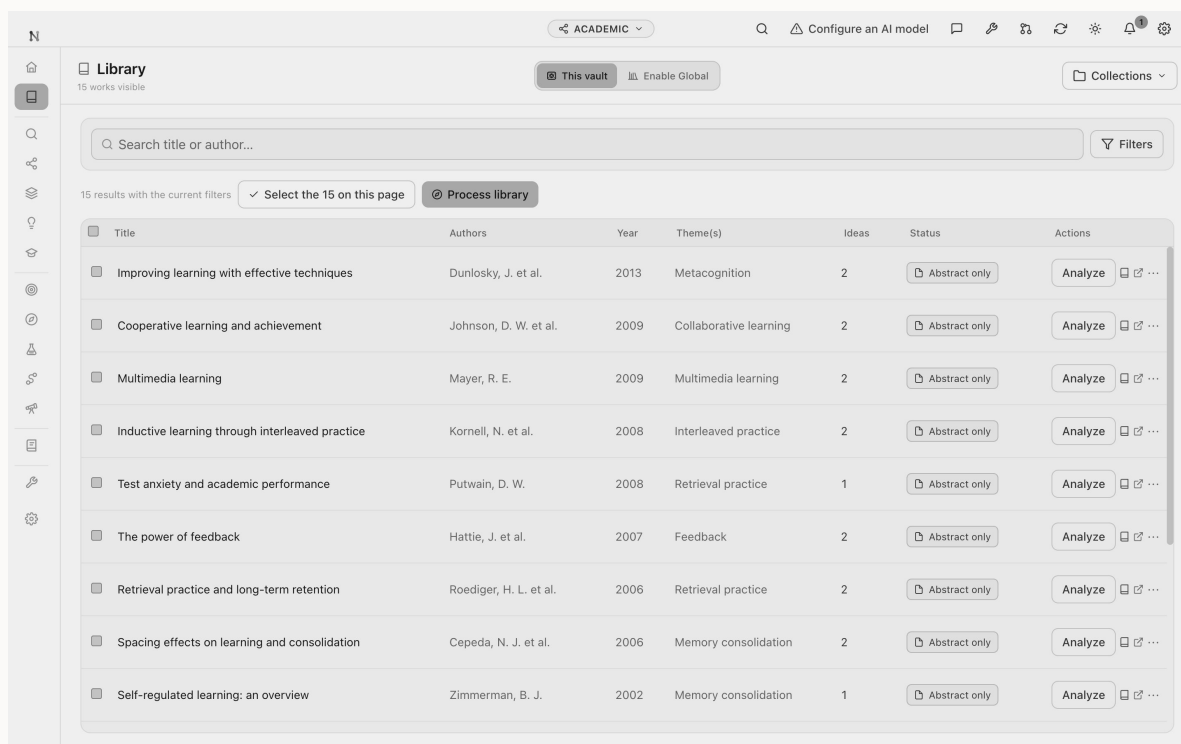
STEP BY STEP

1. Open Library and add a local file, import bibliographic data or connect Zotero.
2. Place the item in a collection and add useful tags; wait for extraction and indexing to finish.

3. Open the item, choose the clean reading copy or preserved original, then highlight passages and link the item into the active vault.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep the preserved original for page-accurate verification.
- Treat automatically extracted text and metadata as a first pass that may need correction.



Library, sources and reader in the Nodus desktop application

CONFIGURATION

5 AI providers and task models

Bring your own cloud key or use compatible local models, with a different model for each task.

Nodus can be used without a model for deterministic organisation and editing. Features that generate, explain or synthesise text need a configured provider or compatible local endpoint. Provider keys are stored in the operating-system keychain, and task models let extraction, chat and reports use different choices.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Left sidebar → Settings → AI and providers

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings and find the AI provider section. Choose a cloud provider or enter the address of a compatible local endpoint.
2. Enter the required credential, use the connection test and resolve any error before continuing.
3. Assign a model to each available task, save the settings and test it on a small, non-sensitive source.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A local model improves privacy but may require more memory and time.
- Review every generated claim against its linked evidence.

CONFIGURATION

6 Privacy, backups and recovery

Protect local work with a verified backup and understand exactly when network services are used.

Vault databases, indexes and library files are local by default. Backups can include all vaults and the shared Library. Nodus reports backup health and creates protected recovery copies before major migrations.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Nodus → Privacy, backups and recovery

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, choose a backup destination and enable automatic backups.
2. Run a manual backup, then use verification to confirm that its manifest and files are readable.
3. Review the privacy notice for each optional online feature before sending content.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Store backups on a different physical device or a trusted encrypted location.
- Do not treat sync as a backup; keep versioned recovery copies.

CONFIGURATION

7 Toolkit and integrations

Convert, protect, translate, OCR and present documents, or connect Zotero, Word, MCP clients and Nodus Server.

Toolkit contains file utilities shared by every vault. Integrations are optional: Zotero supplies bibliographic material, Word can use selected Nodus context, MCP exposes approved local tools, and Nodus Server

publishes a selected copy rather than the source vault.

WHERE TO FIND IT

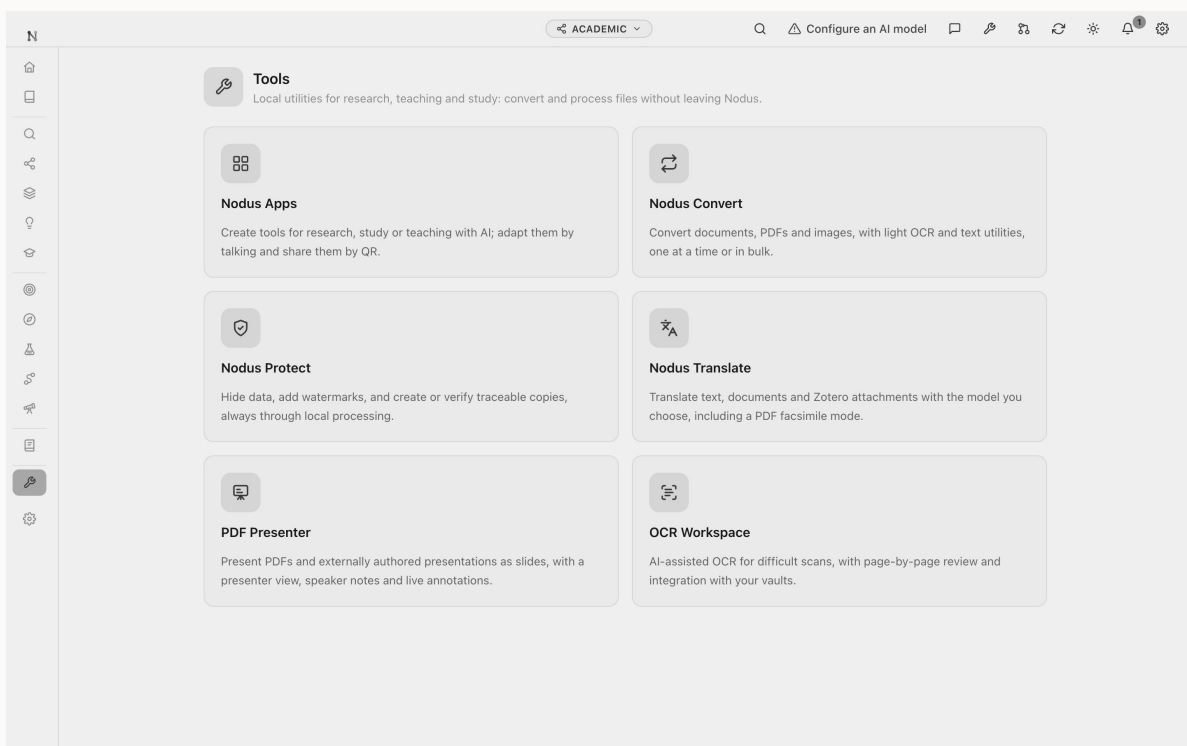
Left sidebar → wrench icon → Toolkit

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Toolkit and choose Convert, Protect, Translate, OCR Workspace or PDF Presenter.
2. Select a file from disk or a compatible vault source, then review every output option and destination.
3. For an integration, enable only the connector you need and test it with a non-sensitive file before using project material.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Permanent redaction in Protect is local and irreversible in the exported copy.
- Published server spaces should contain only material intended for their readers.

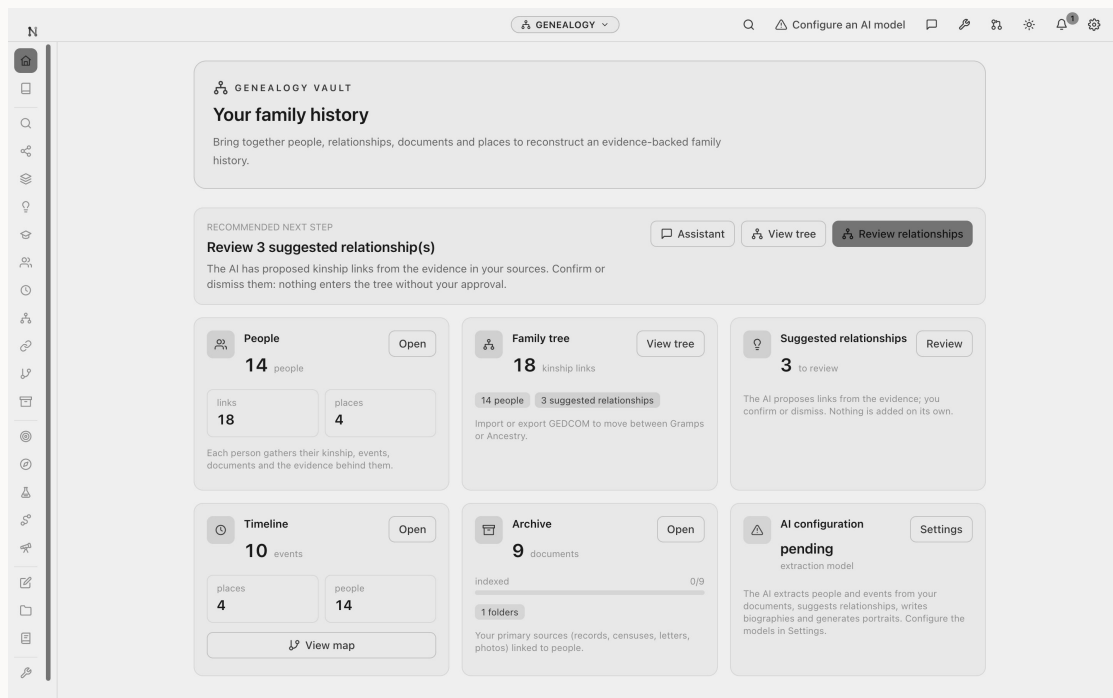


Toolkit and integrations in the Nodus desktop application

PART II · VAULT GUIDE

Complete Genealogy workflow

The Genealogy vault connects a family tree to people, life events, places, social relations, archival records and research notes. Every relationship can be reviewed against evidence.



Genealogy vault home in the Nodus desktop application

ORIENTATION

1 Home and research status

See people, relationships, events, records and suggestions at a glance.

Home highlights recent work and unresolved relationship suggestions so that documentary review stays ahead of decorative tree building.

WHERE TO FIND IT

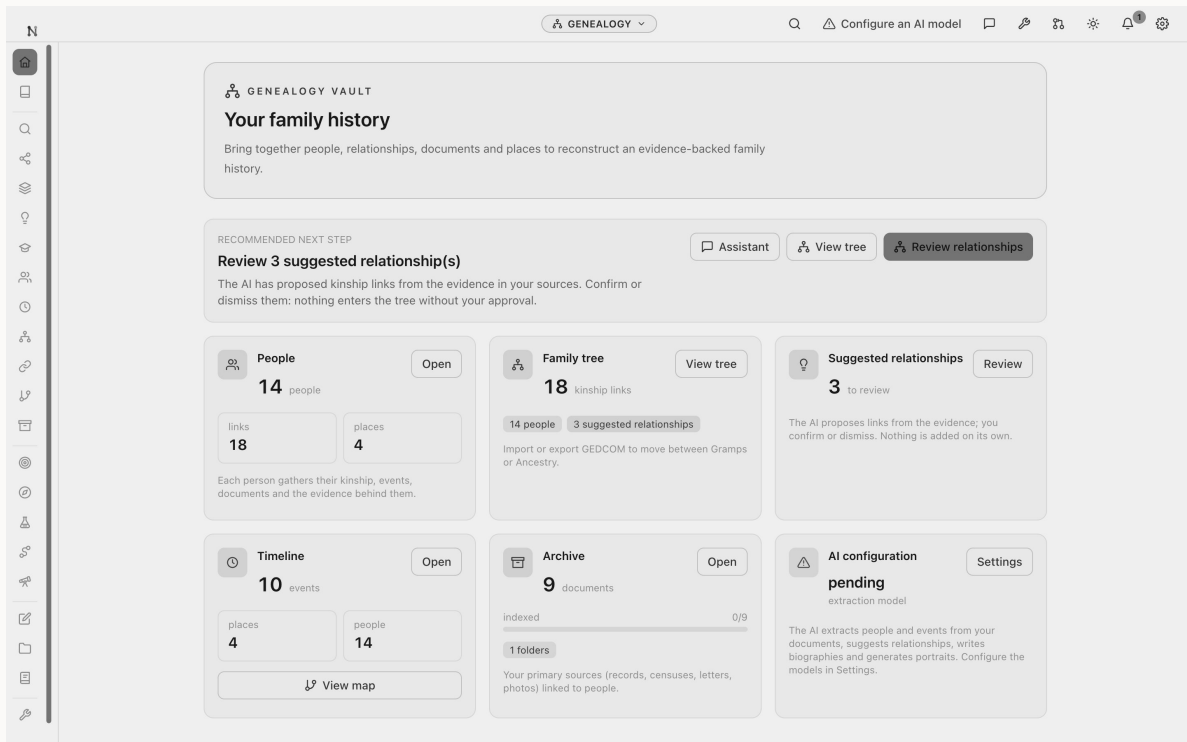
Genealogy vault → Home and research status

STEP BY STEP

1. Review vault totals and recent changes.
2. Open suggested relationships before expanding the tree.
3. Use the Archive or People shortcuts to continue evidence entry.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Record uncertain information explicitly instead of silently choosing one version.



Home and research status in the Nodus desktop application

EXPLORE

2 Vault search

Search people, events and the full text of transcribed records from one box.

Search crosses structured names and dates as well as OCR or transcript text. Results open the corresponding person, event or record.

WHERE TO FIND IT

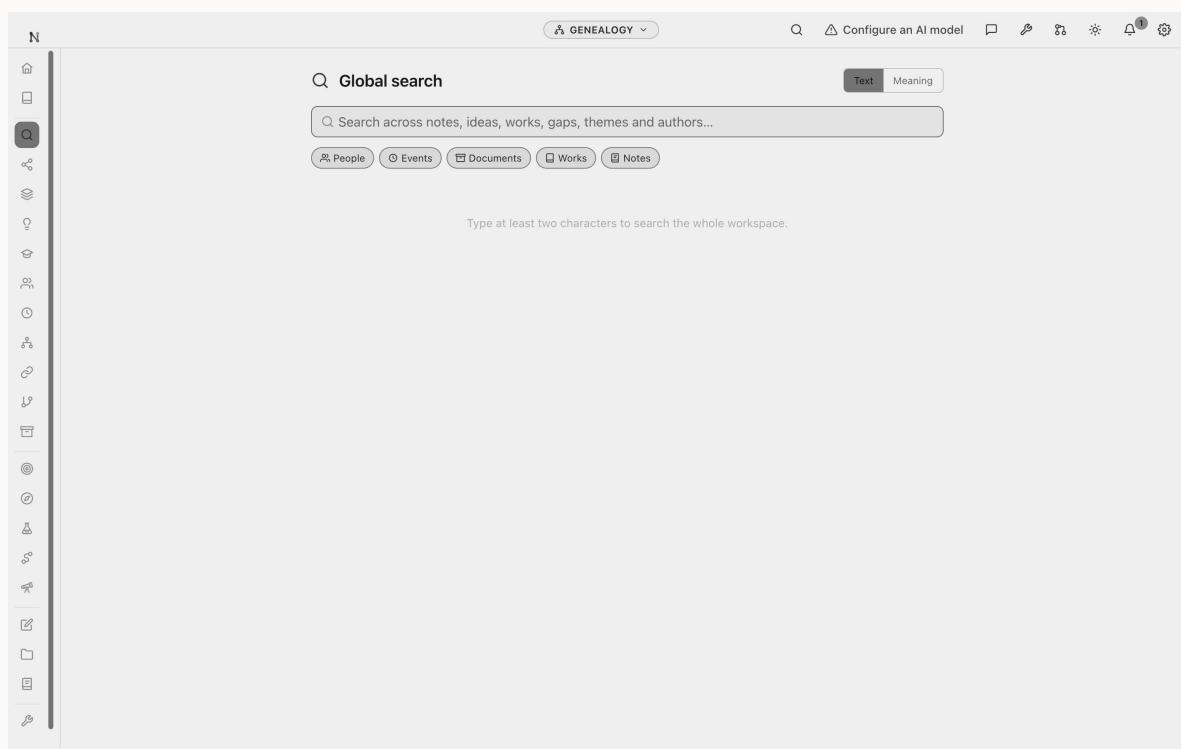
Genealogy vault → Vault search

STEP BY STEP

1. Search a surname, place, occupation, date or phrase from a record.
2. Compare entity types and spelling variants.
3. Open the source result and confirm the transcription against the image.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Try historical spelling variants and nearby place names.



Vault search in the Nodus desktop application

EXPLORE

3 People and profiles

Create a documented profile with names, dates, places, identifiers and linked evidence.

A person profile is the hub for life events, relationships, records and notes. Unknown, approximate and disputed values should remain distinguishable.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Genealogy vault → People and profiles

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a person with the minimum known identity fields.
2. Add life events with dates, places and citations rather than typing an unsupported biography.
3. Link records and relationships, then review duplicate or conflict warnings.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use alternate names for aliases, married names and spelling variants.

EXPLORE

4 Family tree

Navigate ancestors, descendants and partners through an evidence-led tree.

The tree visualises accepted relationships and lets you focus, pan and zoom. It is a navigation surface; the person profile and attached sources remain authoritative.

WHERE TO FIND IT

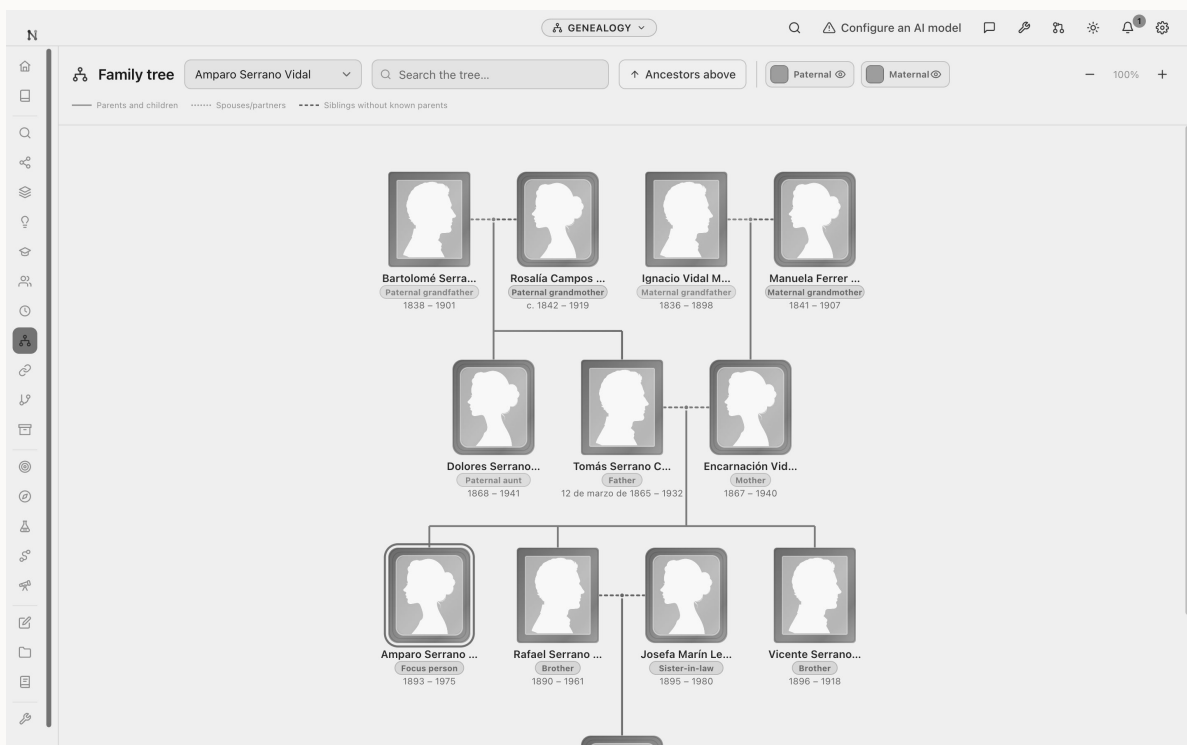
Genealogy vault → Family tree

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Family tree and select a focus person.
2. Expand the relevant generation or branch and inspect relationship markers.
3. Open a person card to verify parents, partners and children against evidence.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Resolve duplicate people before merging branches.



Family tree in the Nodus desktop application

EXPLORE

5 Timeline

Place personal and family events in chronological context.

The timeline brings births, marriages, residences, occupations, deaths and other events together. Filters help isolate one person, branch or period.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Genealogy vault → Timeline

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a date range or person filter.
2. Open an event to inspect date precision, place, participants and sources.
3. Add a note when chronology exposes an impossibility or ambiguity.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep 'about', 'before' and 'after' date precision instead of inventing exact dates.

EXPLORE

6 Social relations

Document witnesses, neighbours, employers and other non-kin connections.

Genealogical evidence often travels through social networks. Typed relations preserve the role, period and documentary basis of each connection.

WHERE TO FIND IT

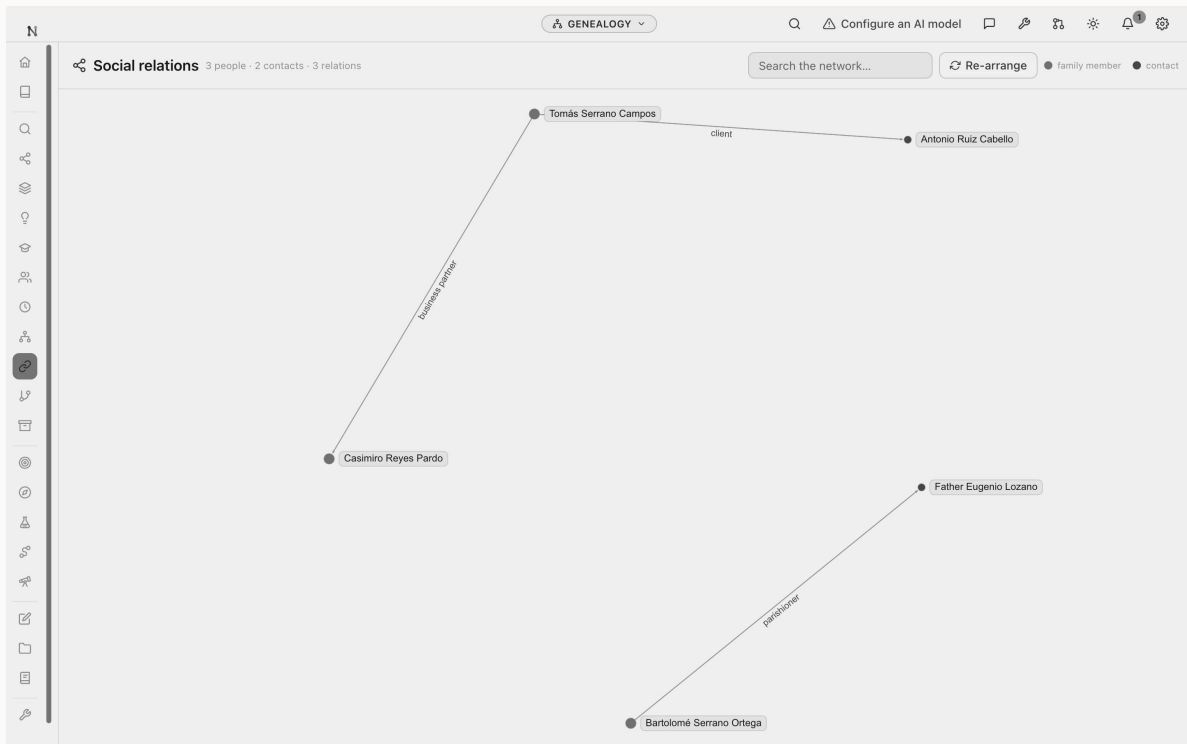
Genealogy vault → Social relations

STEP BY STEP

1. Create or select both people.
2. Choose the relation type, direction and relevant dates.
3. Attach the record or note that supports the connection.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Do not turn every shared record into a permanent relationship; capture context and confidence.



Social relations in the Nodus desktop application

EXPLORE

7 Map

Explore residences, migrations and event locations spatially.

Places are shared structured entities rather than repeated free text. A map point opens the events and people connected to that location.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Genealogy vault → Map

STEP BY STEP

1. Standardise a place name and coordinates.
2. Open Map and filter by person, branch or event type.
3. Follow a point to the underlying events and records.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Preserve the historical place label even when adding modern coordinates.

EXPLORE

8 Archive and records

Preserve certificates, censuses, letters and photographs with transcription, OCR and links.

The Archive stores primary sources separately from secondary literature. Records can be grouped in folders, analysed for text and linked to people and events.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Genealogy vault → Archive and records

STEP BY STEP

1. Import a record and choose an appropriate document type and folder.
2. Review image orientation, OCR or transcription, metadata and source citation.
3. Link every identified person and event, marking uncertain identifications.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep the unedited original image and record archive, collection and call-number provenance.

Title	Description	Archive	Document type	Year	People	Source	Tags
Marriage record of Tomás and E...		PDF	Marriage record	1889	Encarnación Vidal Ferrer x Tomás Serrano Campos x + link	Archivo Parroquial de Sant...	Ca
Carmona census sheet (1900)		CSV	Census / register of in...	1900	Amparo Serrano Vidal x Encarnación Vidal Ferrer x Rafael Serrano Vidal x Tomás Serrano Campos x Vicente Serrano Vidal x + link	Archivo Municipal de Car...	19
Diary of Encarnación Vidal		TEXT	Diary	—	Encarnación Vidal Ferrer x + link	Colección familiar Serrano...	di
Letter from Amparo to her broth...		TEXT	Correspondence	1925	Rafael Serrano Vidal x + link	Colección familiar Serrano...	ca
Death record of Vicente Serrano...		PDF	Death record	1918	Vicente Serrano Vidal x + link	Registro Civil de Sevilla · S...	Se
Studio portrait of the Serrano fa...	Fotografía de estudio en sepia: un ...	IMAGE	Photograph	1905	Amparo Serrano Vidal x Encarnación Vidal Ferrer x Rafael Serrano Vidal x Tomás Serrano Campos x + link	Álbum fotográfico de la fa...	fo
Marriage record of Dolores Serra...		PDF	Marriage record	1890	Casimiro Reyes Pardo x Dolores Serrano Campos x + link	Archivo Parroquial de Sant...	Ca

7 documents

Archive and records in the Nodus desktop application

EXPLORE

9 Secondary literature

Use the shared Library for histories and methods that frame the reconstruction.

Books and articles belong in Library while certificates and family photographs belong in Archive. Both can inform notes and reports without collapsing their evidential roles.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Genealogy vault → Secondary literature

STEP BY STEP

1. Import relevant local histories or connect Zotero.
2. Link the source into the genealogy vault.
3. Highlight passages that clarify context, method or place history.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A published family tree is not automatically a primary source.

ANALYSE

10 Genealogy Deep Research

Synthesize a lineage or research question from structured records and notes.

Reports can combine people, events, places, archival records and secondary literature while retaining citations and uncertainty language.

WHERE TO FIND IT

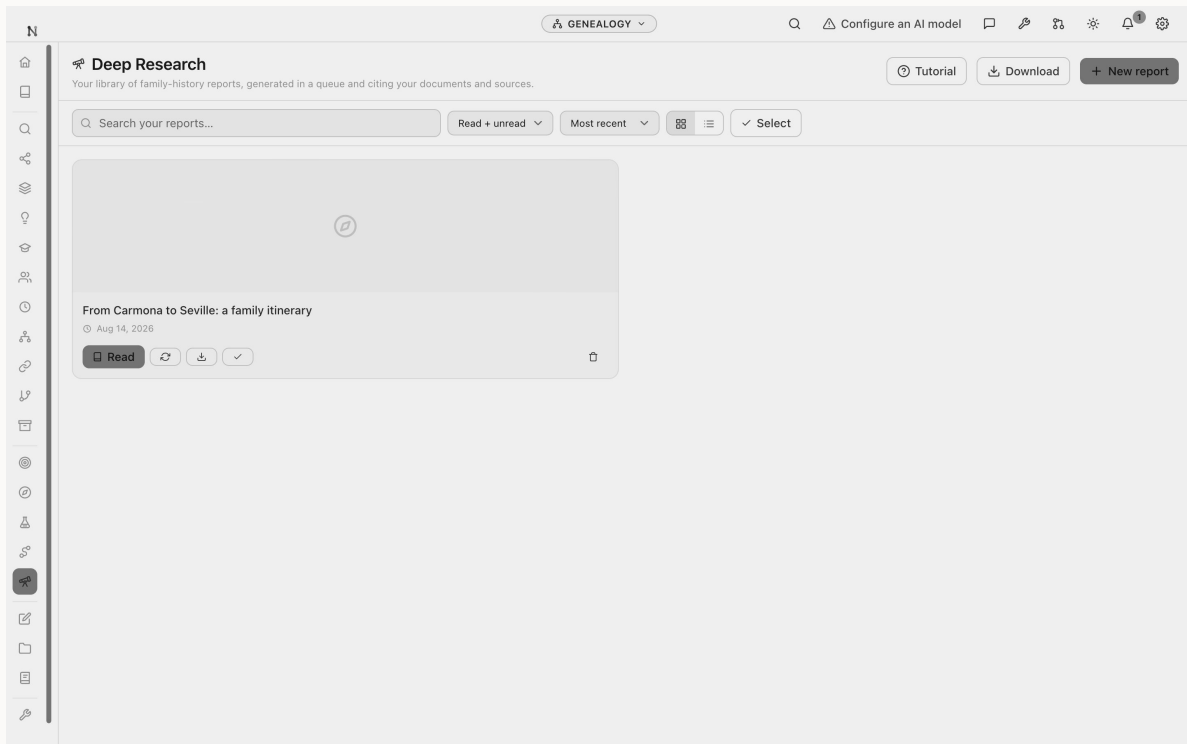
Genealogy vault → Genealogy Deep Research

STEP BY STEP

1. Ask a bounded question about a person, branch, migration or conflict.
2. Choose the relevant scope and start the queued report.
3. Audit every relationship and date in the result against the cited record.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A report should preserve conflicting evidence rather than silently resolve it.



Genealogy Deep Research in the Nodus desktop application

WRITE

11 Research notes

Keep hypotheses, transcription decisions and next searches linked to the evidence.

Notes provide flexible space for reasoning that does not yet belong in a person or event record. Links prevent conclusions from becoming detached from their sources.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Genealogy vault → Research notes

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a note with a question-oriented title.
2. Link people, records and places mentioned in the note.
3. Separate observed facts, interpretations and next actions.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Maintain a research log for negative searches as well as discoveries.

EXCHANGE

12 GEDCOM import and export

Exchange structured family data while reviewing what the format cannot preserve.

GEDCOM can seed or share people and family relations, but application-specific evidence, notes and media may not round-trip perfectly.

WHERE TO FIND IT

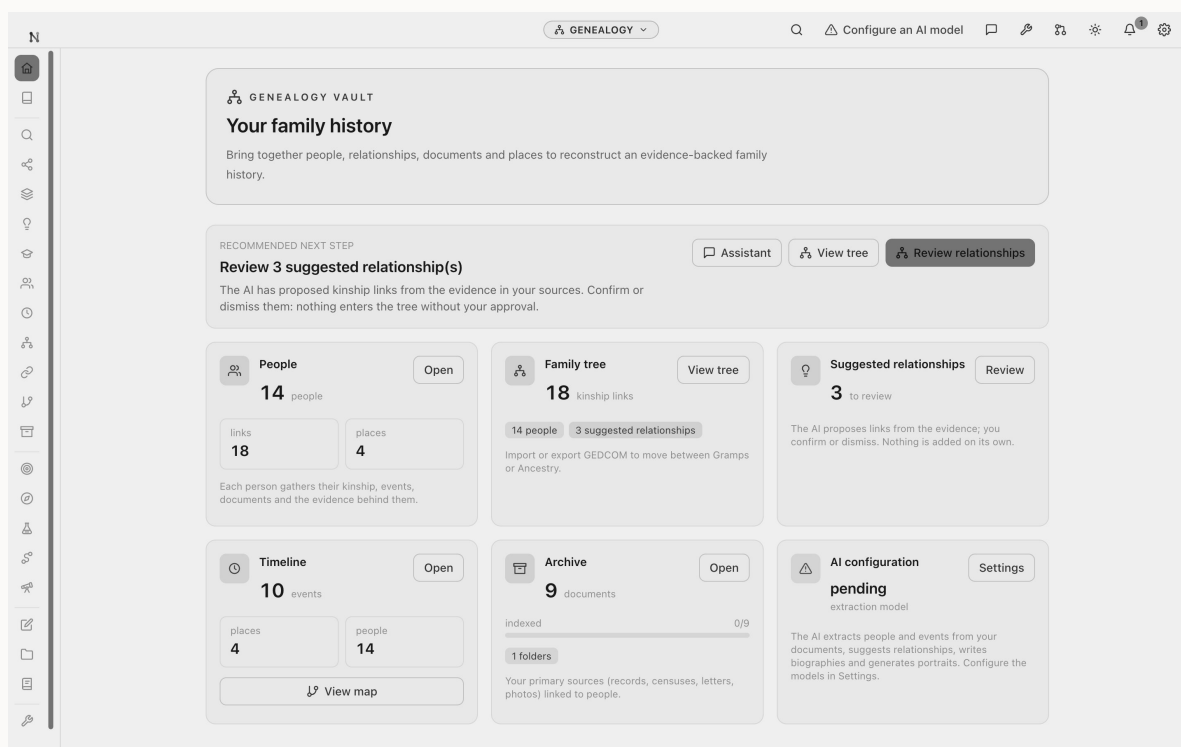
Genealogy vault → GEDCOM import and export

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a backup, then preview a GEDCOM import and its duplicates or warnings.
2. Map or review people and relationships before committing.
3. After export, open the file in a second tool and verify names, dates and links.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Never treat GEDCOM transfer as a full archival backup.



GEDCOM import and export in the Nodus desktop application

CONFIGURE

13 Genealogy settings

Configure OCR, Library, maps, models, integrations and backups.

Settings control extraction and optional analysis while keeping the genealogy database local.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Genealogy vault → Genealogy settings

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose OCR and transcription defaults suitable for the records.
2. Review provider and model choices before analysing sensitive documents.
3. Enable automatic backups and verify a restore point.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Living-person data deserves stricter sharing and provider choices.

REFERENCE

Completion checklist

- The vault scope and name match the project.
- Sources or records have preserved originals and reviewed metadata.
- Generated interpretations have been checked against their evidence.
- Optional providers and integrations use only the intended data.
- Exports have been proofread in their final format.
- A recent backup has been created and verified.

This manual documents the desktop workflow represented in Nodus 4.1. Interface details may evolve between releases; the in-app privacy notice and release notes govern the exact behaviour of the installed version.